Spandrels from an Archway

From the mosque of Sultan Barquq (786-88 AH / 1384-86 CE)

Burji Mamluk, 786-88 or mid-9th century AH / 1384-86 or mid-15th century CE

W: 73 cm; H: 23.4 cm

Inv. no. 466



These spandrels, likely forming part of the front door frame of a minbar of uncertain provenance in the mosque of Sultan Barquq (786-88 AH / 1384-86 CE), are carved in relief with prominent scrolling arabesques, trilobed fleurons, large leaves, and curling buds, contrasting with the relatively plain and garishly gilded minbar currently on-site. While Sultan Barquq may have originally commissioned a minbar for the site, historical records indicate it was replaced in the mid-fifteenth century by another minbar associated with Sultan al-Zahir Jaqmaq (r. 842-57 AH / 1438-53 CE); the ultimate fate of both furnishings remains uncertain. Though removed from its original setting, this piece nevertheless conveys the subtlety of Mamluk craftsmanship and the enduring appeal of its ornamental language.

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